

Notebook category, the Genius VideoCAM Eye and VideoCAM Messenger supported it. Of course, we didn't give this feature much importance since digital zoom causes images to appear grainy because of the software interpolation of the actual image to a higher resolution. The Microsoft webcams output better quality when zoomed.

Physical Features

As we've already mentioned, still photography was supported by every webcam we received. To add to this, there is also a snapshot button in many webcam models that let you take snapshots without needing to open up the software interface. Just press the snapshot button and the photograph opens on your desktop—of course, the software needs to be running in the background.

The Genius Look 312P, Logitech QuickCam Go and QuickCam Messenger lacked a snapshot button in the PC category while the rest had one. All the webcams in the Notebook category had snapshot buttons.

Vertical swivel was available in all webcams in both the categories. The Genius Look 312P, which is shaped like a soft-toy dog, had only vertical swivel—no

horizontal swivel. The Logitech QuickCam for Notebooks Deluxe also did not have horizontal swivel, but featured a face-tracking feature to compensate. Swivel is an important feature—it lets you adjust the webcam to face the subject easily.

Next, we checked whether the cams featured a clamp of any sort to secure them to a laptop monitor or an LCD. Needless to say, this feature was present on all the webcams in



Microsoft LifeCam VX-6000
Life-like image quality

the Notebook category. In addition to this feature, the Logitech QuickCam Image also had a pedestal, allowing you to use it as a PC webcam. Amongst the PC webcams, the Genius Look 312P and 315FS, Logitech QuickCam Go, and Microsoft LifeCam VX-3000 and VX-6000 did not have such clamps.

A long USB cable is always an advantage. USB extender cables are available to augment the length of the USB cable, but the ones that are available in our markets do not have amplifiers, so the signal quality suffers. Sometimes because of the weak signal strength, the webcam may not even be recognised by the PC. Logitech made it a point to provide six-foot cables with all their webcams, except the QuickCam Image. The rest of the webcams came with standard length USB cables. The Genius Look 312P had a very short cable, but came with a USB extension cable.

Software

Windows was the operating system universally supported by all the webcams. Genius deviated from the trend by offering support for other operating systems as well. Linux users will be delighted to find that the

Crittercams And More

Marine biologist Greg Marshall, while diving off the coast of Belize in 1986, encountered a shark. He noticed a remora fish attached to its underside, and it occurred to him that deploying a camera in place of the fish would let him observe the shark's behaviour without any human interference. He built a prototype and deployed it on a sea turtle the following year. True to expectations, the turtle behaved normally even with the camera attached. This later came to be known as the Crittercam.

Crittercams are the National Geographic Society's research cameras, worn by wild animals. These have been deployed on over 40 species of animals such as sharks, sea turtles, whales, penguins and more. Later, the Crittercam research program was expanded to include terrestrial animals such as lions, hyenas, and grizzly bears. Their purpose is to allow scientists to study animal behaviour and ecology. Crittercams record not only video and sound, but also collect environmental data such as depth underwater, temperature and acceleration.

Crittercams help us learn how animals use their habitat, where they feed, what they eat, and how they



A sea turtle fitted with a Crittercam

interact with other animals.

To learn more about crittercams, visit <http://channel.nationalgeographic.com/channel/crittercam>. You can also view some of the archived videos.

You're probably never going to take a trip to Antarctica, but you can get an idea of the weather there by going to the Mawson Station Webcam site. The Web site of the Australian Antarctic Division has put a camera in

Antarctica. This video camera sends images and video to the Australian Antarctic Division's Headquarters located at Kingston, Tasmania, via a permanent satellite link. Find it at <http://www.aad.gov.au/asset/webcams/mawson/default.asp>. The pictures on this page are updated every 10 minutes. You can also view breathtakingly stunning timelapse movies captured the previous day. There are many webcams you'll be able to access at this Web site, for different views of Antarctica.

The Mount St. Helens VolcanoCam, Washington state, USA, broadcasts live images of this active volcano over the Internet. To view the VolcanoCam, visit <http://www.fs.fed.us/gpnp/volcanocams>.

Helmut Halfmann's Realtime Camera Paradise at www.wildweb.de is an amazing Web site. Here, you can view a lot of places around the world—live—via webcams installed at these places. Just enter the site and click on "realtime cams". Not only can you see images from all over Earth, but also some from outer space!